Work & study

A conversational idiom workbook: 16 phrases, each with a short conversation and four quick tasks. Do it online and check your answers, or print it and use the answer key at the end.

In this workbook

1. **breathing down your neck**: Watching someone very closely, so they feel pressure.
2. **drop the ball**: To make a mistake by forgetting or failing to do something you should do.
3. **get through**: To finish something long or difficult.
4. **the ins and outs**: The ins and outs are all the small details of how something works.
5. **leeway**: Extra freedom or flexibility that lets you do something a little differently or later.
6. **a leg up**: An advantage that helps you do better than others.
7. **make up (work or time)**: To do work or time later because you missed it earlier.
8. **on my behalf**: Instead of someone, or for them, as their representative.
9. **part and parcel**: Something that is a normal, necessary part of a situation or job.
10. **pick someone's brain**: To ask someone who knows a lot about a subject for advice or ideas.
11. **side hustle**: A small extra job you do in addition to your main job.
12. **spread yourself thin**: To try to do too many things at once, so you can't do any of them well.
13. **team up**: To join someone and work together to do something.
14. **toe the line**: To obey the rules and do what is expected.
15. **touch base**: To contact someone briefly to share news or check how things are going.
16. **use it or lose it**: If you don't use a skill or something you have, you will lose it.

How to use it: read the conversation out loud first, then do the four tasks. For the last task, answer out loud before you write, and try to use the phrase naturally.

breathing down your neck

Idiom | Level B2 | Casual

Watching someone very closely, so they feel pressure.

Tip: Use it with a person or group as the subject: 'someone is breathing down my neck' (usually while you are working on something), and don't use it for a literal breath.

Mei: Are you still working on the report? It's nearly eight.

Diego: Yeah, I'm stuck on the last section. The client keeps emailing me for updates.

Mei: Every hour?

Diego: Pretty much. With them breathing down my neck, I can't think straight.

Mei: Turn off your notifications for an hour. You'll finish faster.

1. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does 'breathing down my neck' mean?

- ○ A. Standing very close to him in the office
- ○ B. Checking on his work all the time, which makes him feel pressure
- ○ C. Giving him helpful advice about the report
- ○ D. Waiting patiently until he is ready

2. Fill the gap

My landlord keeps phoning to ask if I've sent the form yet. I wish he would stop

_____ .

3. Choose the best reply

Olena: *I'm so nervous about the presentation. My manager is going to watch every minute of it.*

- ○ A. I know, she's been breathing down your neck all week, hasn't she?
- ○ B. Be careful, she might breathe down your neck on the way to the room.
- ○ C. Don't worry, I'll breathe down your neck so you stay calm.

4. Your turn: speak

Tell me about a time when someone put pressure on you while you were trying to get something done.

drop the ball

Idiom | Level B2 | Casual

To make a mistake by forgetting or failing to do something you should do.

Tip: Use it as 'drop the ball (on something)': you can say 'I dropped the ball' about yourself or 'someone dropped the ball' about a team, and it is usually about a task you were responsible for, not a physical accident.

Olena: Did the landlord ever fix the heating in the flat?

Diego: No. I said I'd call him last week, but I got busy.

Olena: It's getting really cold in the evenings, though.

Diego: I know. I really dropped the ball on that one.

Olena: Don't worry, call him first thing tomorrow.

Diego: I will. I'll set a reminder on my phone right now.

5. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does 'dropped the ball' mean?

- ○ A. Diego broke something in the flat
- ○ B. Diego argued with the landlord
- ○ C. Diego decided not to rent the flat any more
- ○ D. Diego failed to do something he had promised to do

6. Fill the gap

Nobody sent the final report to the client, so someone clearly _____ somewhere along the way.

7. Choose the best reply

Kofi: *The tickets were supposed to be booked by Friday, and now the train is fully sold out!*

- ○ A. Don't worry, I'll drop the ball for you tomorrow.
- ○ B. Sorry, I dropped the ball. It slipped out of my hand at the station.
- ○ C. Sorry, I dropped the ball. I meant to do it and forgot.

8. Your turn: speak

Tell me about a time when you forgot to do something important. What happened?

_____

_____

_____

get through

Phrasal verb | Level B1 | Neutral

To finish something long or difficult.

Tip: Use 'get through' + a noun for a big task (get through the pile, the book, the week); it often suggests effort, so don't use it for something quick or easy.

Olena: Are you still at your desk? It's nearly eight.

Kofi: I know. I've got forty job applications to read by tomorrow morning.

Olena: Forty? That's a lot. How many have you done?

Kofi: Only twelve. I'm not sure I'll get through them all tonight.

Olena: Want me to take ten? I can read them on the train.

Kofi: Yes, please. You've saved my evening.

9. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does "get through" mean?

- ○ A. To travel from one place to another
- ○ B. To pass an interview or exam successfully
- ○ C. To finish a large amount of work, even though it takes effort
- ○ D. To contact someone by phone

10. Fill the gap

If we split the boxes between us, we should _____ them all before the movers arrive.

11. Choose the best reply

Amira: *You look exhausted. How was your first week at the new job?*

- ○ A. Honestly, there was so much training that I could barely get through it.
- ○ B. I got through my desk on the first morning.
- ○ C. My manager got through me to the second floor.

12. Your turn: speak

Tell me about a time when you had a lot to do and not much time. How did you manage?

_____

_____

_____

the ins and outs

Idiom | Level B2 | Neutral

The ins and outs are all the small details of how something works.

Tip: Almost always used as 'the ins and outs of + noun' after verbs like learn, know, understand or explain; it's plural, so don't say 'the in and out'.

Olena: Are you ready for your first shift at the bakery tomorrow?

Kofi: A bit nervous, honestly. I don't know the ins and outs of the ordering system yet.

Olena: Don't worry, nobody does on day one. Who's training you?

Kofi: Amira. She's been there for five years, so she'll show me everything.

Olena: Perfect. Just ask lots of questions and you'll be fine.

13. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does the ins and outs mean?

- ○ A. The good and bad points of a job
- ○ B. The basic rules you must follow on your first day
- ○ C. All the small details of how something works
- ○ D. The times when people come in and go out of a place

14. Fill the gap

My brother has owned a restaurant for years, so he knows _____ of running a small business.

15. Choose the best reply

Ken: *I'm thinking of buying a second-hand car, but I've never done it before.*

- ○ A. Good idea. The ins and outs of the car were really clean when I looked.
- ○ B. Yes, I always drive the ins and outs of the city on weekends.
- ○ C. Ask Diego. He knows the ins and outs of buying cars, so he can warn you about the common problems.

16. Your turn: speak

Tell me about something you learned to do that was harder than you expected.

_____

_____

_____

leeway

Expression · Level C1 · Neutral

Extra freedom or flexibility that lets you do something a little differently or later.

Tip: Usually used as 'give someone leeway' or 'have some leeway'; it's an uncountable noun, so don't say 'a leeway' or 'leeways'.

Olena: Are you sure you can finish the report by Friday? It's a lot.

Kofi: I'm trying. The client sent their numbers really late.

Olena: Could you ask for a few extra days?

Kofi: I already did. They said there's some leeway, as long as I send a draft on Friday.

Olena: That's a relief. So the draft is enough for now?

Kofi: Yes, and I can polish the rest on Monday.

17. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does 'there's some leeway' mean?

- ○ A. There is a serious problem with the report.
- ○ B. There is not enough time to finish anything.
- ○ C. There is a little flexibility about the deadline.
- ○ D. There is a rule that cannot be changed.

18. Fill the gap

The teacher didn't mind if we handed in the essay a day late, so we had a bit of _____.

19. Choose the best reply

Amira: *I'm worried I'll be ten minutes late on my first day. Is that okay?*

- ○ A. Don't worry, they usually allow a bit of leeway on the first day.
- ○ B. Don't worry, you can leeway them if you arrive late.
- ○ C. Don't worry, ten minutes is a very leeway amount of time.

20. Your turn: speak

Tell me about a time when someone gave you some flexibility with a rule or a plan. How did it help?

a leg up

Idiom · Level B2 · Casual

An advantage that helps you do better than others.

Tip: Use it as 'give someone a leg up' or 'get a leg up'; it's friendly and common in everyday speech, but don't confuse it with 'pull someone's leg', which means to joke.

Olena: Did you hear? Kofi got the job at the design studio.

Diego: Really? That's great. He only finished his degree in June.

Olena: Yes, but his uncle runs a similar company, and Kofi worked there every summer.

Diego: So that gave him a leg up over the other candidates.

Olena: Definitely. But he's also talented, so he deserves it.

21. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does "a leg up" mean?

- ○ A. A physical injury that makes it hard to work
- ○ B. A small amount of extra money
- ○ C. A joke that someone tells to make a person feel relaxed
- ○ D. An advantage that helps someone do better than others

22. Fill the gap

Learning Spanish as a child gave Amira _____ when she started working in international sales.

23. Choose the best reply

Mei: *I'm nervous about starting university. Everyone else seems so prepared.*

- ○ A. Don't worry. The summer course you took will give you a leg up.
- ○ B. Don't worry. Everyone is going to leg up you in the first week.
- ○ C. Don't worry. You'll have to leg up when classes begin.

24. Your turn: speak

Can you think of something that gave you a leg up in your studies or career? Tell me about it.

make up (work or time)

Phrasal verb | Level B1 | Neutral

To do work or time later because you missed it earlier.

Tip: Use it with an object: 'make up the hours / the class / the time'; it's about doing something you missed, not inventing it, so don't confuse it with 'make something up'.

Olena: Are you free to leave early on Friday? A few of us are going to the lake.

Kofi: I'd love to, but I was off sick on Tuesday and Wednesday.

Olena: Does your manager care about the missed hours?

Kofi: A little. I need to make up the time before the weekend.

Olena: Then come in early on Thursday and finish at lunchtime on Friday.

Kofi: Good idea. I'll ask her this afternoon.

25. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does "make up the time" mean?

- ○ A. Work extra hours to replace the hours he missed
- ○ B. Ask his manager to forgive the missed hours
- ○ C. Invent an excuse for why he was away
- ○ D. Decide what time to start work each day

26. Fill the gap

The train strike made me late all week, so I have to _____ the hours on Saturday.

27. Choose the best reply

Amira: *Sorry I missed the group study session yesterday. My bus broke down.*

- ○ A. No problem. Do you want to make up the session with me tomorrow?
- ○ B. No problem. I'll make up the session about your bus.
- ○ C. No problem. You always make up with the group on Fridays.

28. Your turn: speak

Tell me about a time you missed work, a class or an appointment. How did you deal with it?

_____

_____

_____

on my behalf

Expression · Level B2 · Neutral

Instead of someone, or for them, as their representative.

Tip: Use 'on someone's behalf' (or 'on behalf of someone') before or after the verb: 'sign on my behalf', 'speak on behalf of the team'; don't confuse it with 'on behalf' used alone or with 'in favour of'.

Olena: Are you still coming to the landlord meeting on Thursday?

Kofi: I can't, I'll be at the airport. Could you talk to him on my behalf?

Olena: Sure. What do you want me to say?

Kofi: Just ask when they'll fix the heating. And please write down what he says.

Olena: No problem. I'll message you right after the meeting.

29. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does "on my behalf" mean?

- ○ A. In a way that I would prefer
- ○ B. Instead of me, as my representative
- ○ C. Because of something I did
- ○ D. Together with me at the same time

30. Fill the gap

Ken was away, so Amira signed the delivery form _____ .

31. Choose the best reply

Diego: *I'm stuck in traffic and I'll miss the start of the presentation. Can you do something for me?*

- ○ A. Of course. I'll introduce the project on behalf, and you can speak later.
- ○ B. Of course. Do you want me to introduce the project on your behalf?
- ○ C. Of course. I'll introduce the project behalf of you when you arrive.

32. Your turn: speak

Have you ever asked someone to do something for you because you couldn't do it yourself? What happened?

_____

_____

_____

part and parcel

Idiom | Level B2 | Neutral

Something that is a normal, necessary part of a situation or job.

Tip: Use 'X is part and parcel of Y' (or 'come as part and parcel of Y'); it often follows a downside, and the phrase is fixed, so don't change the word order or say 'part and a parcel'.

Olena: You look exhausted, Kofi. Another late shift at the clinic?

Kofi: Yes, and I had three patients who were really upset today. I'm starting to wonder if I'm cut out for this.

Olena: Honestly, I think difficult days are part and parcel of nursing. Even the most experienced nurses get them.

Kofi: I suppose you're right. It's just harder than I expected in my first year.

Olena: It gets easier. Go home, eat something proper and get some sleep.

33. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does "part and parcel" mean?

- ○ A. A small piece that can easily be removed
- ○ B. The most enjoyable part of a job
- ○ C. A task that is shared equally between people
- ○ D. A normal and unavoidable part of something

34. Fill the gap

Living in a big city means noise and crowded trains are _____ of daily life.

35. Choose the best reply

Amira: *I hate how much paperwork there is in this job.*

- ○ A. Well, it's part and parcel of working in a hospital, I'm afraid.
- ○ B. Yes, the paperwork is part and parcel, so I never do it.
- ○ C. That's lucky! It's part and parcel of a very short day.

36. Your turn: speak

Tell me about a job or activity that has some unpleasant parts. How do you feel about them?

pick someone's brain

Idiom | Level B2 | Casual

To ask someone who knows a lot about a subject for advice or ideas.

Tip: Use it as 'pick someone's brain (about/on something)'; it's friendly and a little informal, so it works best with colleagues and friends, and the person is usually asked for a short chat, not a favour that takes hours.

Olena: I heard you finished a master's in data science part-time.

Kofi: I did, two years of evenings and weekends. Why, are you thinking about it?

Olena: Maybe. Do you have time for coffee this week? I'd love to pick your brain about the application process.

Kofi: Sure, Thursday works. I'll bring my old notes and tell you what I wish I'd known.

Olena: That would be amazing. I'll buy the coffee.

37. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does "pick your brain" mean?

- ○ A. Ask someone with experience for advice and ideas
- ○ B. Disagree with someone's opinion in a friendly way
- ○ C. Test someone's knowledge with difficult questions
- ○ D. Borrow someone's notes and study materials

38. Fill the gap

My cousin runs a small bakery, so I'm going to _____ before I open my own café.

39. Choose the best reply

Amira: *I'm thinking of renting out my flat while I travel, but I have no idea where to start. You've done it, haven't you?*

- ○ A. Yes, I have. Want to meet up so you can pick my brain about it?
- ○ B. Yes, I have. Don't pick my brain, it's already full of other things.
- ○ C. Yes, I have. I'll pick your brain and send you a list of tips.

40. Your turn: speak

Tell me about a time you asked someone for advice before making a big decision.

_____

_____

_____

side hustle

Expression | Level B2 | Casual

A small extra job you do in addition to your main job.

Tip: Use it as a countable noun: 'have a side hustle', 'start a side hustle', 'do something as a side hustle'. It often suggests a way to earn extra money, and people usually say it about their own or a friend's small business.

Ken: You look tired today. Did you stay up late again?

Olena: Yes, I was editing photos until almost one.

Ken: For work? I thought you finished at six.

Olena: Not for my office job. I've started a side hustle doing wedding photography on weekends.

Ken: That's great! Is it going well?

Olena: So far, yes. I already have four bookings for next spring.

41. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does side hustle mean?

- ○ A. A job you do instead of your main job after you quit
- ○ B. A small extra job you do besides your main job
- ○ C. A hobby you do only for fun and never for money
- ○ D. A stressful problem that follows you from work to home

42. Fill the gap

Kofi teaches maths during the day, but he also tutors online in the evenings as a _____.

43. Choose the best reply

Diego: *I'm getting a bit tired of my job, and the pay isn't great either.*

- ○ A. Maybe you could side hustle your boss and ask for a raise.
- ○ B. Maybe you could start a side hustle to bring in some extra money.
- ○ C. Maybe you should quit your side hustle and work harder at your main job.

44. Your turn: speak

Do you think it's a good idea for people to have a side hustle? Why or why not?

_____

_____

_____

spread yourself thin

Idiom | Level B2 | Neutral

To try to do too many things at once, so you can't do any of them well.

Tip: Use it as 'spread yourself (too) thin', changing the pronoun to match the subject: 'I'm spreading myself too thin', 'He tends to spread himself thin'.

Olena: Are you coming to the study group on Thursday?

Diego: I wish I could, but I've got my evening classes, the extra shifts at the café, and my cousin's moving next week.

Olena: That's a lot. Honestly, I think you're spreading yourself thin.

Diego: I know. I said yes to everything, and now my exam notes are a mess.

Olena: Maybe drop one thing for a few weeks? Even just the extra shifts.

Diego: Yeah, you're right. I'll talk to my manager tomorrow.

45. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does 'spreading yourself thin' mean?

- ○ A. Losing weight because you are too busy to eat properly
- ○ B. Spending your money carefully so it lasts longer
- ○ C. Taking on so many commitments that you can't do any of them well
- ○ D. Sharing your work fairly with the other people around you

46. Fill the gap

If you keep volunteering for every project, you'll end up _____ and none of them will get your full attention.

47. Choose the best reply

Amira: *I'm running the school fundraiser, training for a marathon, and starting a night course this month.*

- ○ A. Wow, careful you don't spread yourself too thin.
- ○ B. Wow, you must have a lot of free time to spread.
- ○ C. Wow, I hope you don't spread thin for the others.

48. Your turn: speak

Have you ever taken on too many things at once? What happened?

_____

_____

_____

team up

Phrasal verb | Level B1 | Neutral

To join someone and work together to do something.

Tip: Use 'team up with someone' or 'team up to do something'; it often describes a choice to work together, so it's common in plans, projects and games.

Olena: Have you started the group presentation yet? I'm still stuck on the slides.

Kofi: Not really. I've got the research done, but my design skills are terrible.

Olena: Well, I'm good at design but I hate searching for data.

Kofi: Then why don't we team up? You make the slides, and I'll send you everything I found.

Olena: Perfect. Send me your notes tonight and I'll start tomorrow morning.

49. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does "team up" mean?

- ○ A. Choose someone to be the leader of a group
- ○ B. Work together with someone to get something done
- ○ C. Join a sports team at university
- ○ D. Pay someone to finish a task for you

50. Fill the gap

My sister and I decided to _____ and paint the whole flat in one weekend.

51. Choose the best reply

Ken: *I can't carry all these boxes up the stairs by myself.*

- ○ A. Don't worry, I'll team up these boxes for you.
- ○ B. Don't worry, let's team up and do it together.
- ○ C. Don't worry, you should team up the stairs first.

52. Your turn: speak

Tell me about a time you worked with someone else to finish something difficult. What happened?

toe the line

Idiom | Level C1 | Neutral

To obey the rules and do what is expected.

Tip: Often used with 'have to', 'make someone', or 'refuse to'; it can sound a little negative, as if the rules are strict or the person has no real choice.

Mei: Did Ravi get the manager job in the end?

Diego: He did, and he's already a different person in meetings.

Mei: Really? He used to argue with everyone.

Diego: I know. Now he has to toe the line, because the director is watching him closely.

Mei: Poor guy. That sounds stressful.

Diego: Honestly, I think he'll be fine once he settles in.

53. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does 'toe the line' mean?

- ○ A. To work much harder than everyone else
- ○ B. To stand in a queue and wait patiently
- ○ C. To be the first person to arrive at work
- ○ D. To follow the rules and behave as expected

54. Fill the gap

My brother hates his new school because the teachers expect every student to _____ and never ask questions.

55. Choose the best reply

Olena: *Are you going to speak up about the new schedule at the meeting?*

- ○ A. Yes, I always toe the line when I want to change the rules.
- ○ B. No, I'd rather toe the line until I've been here a bit longer.
- ○ C. No, I'll toe the line to the meeting room on the third floor.

56. Your turn: speak

Tell me about a time when you had to follow strict rules at work or school. How did you feel about it?

_____

_____

_____

touch base

Idiom | Level B2 | Neutral

To contact someone briefly to share news or check how things are going.

Tip: Use it as a verb, often with 'with' + person or 'on' + topic: 'I'll touch base with Ken tomorrow.' It's common at work but also fine between friends; don't use it for a long, serious meeting.

Olena: Hi Kofi, did you get the quote from the printing company?

Kofi: Not yet. They said they'd send it today, but nothing has arrived.

Olena: Could you touch base with them this afternoon? We need to order by Monday.

Kofi: Sure. I'll give them a quick call after lunch.

Olena: Thanks. Let me know what they say.

57. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does "touch base with them" mean?

- ○ A. Contact them briefly to check on progress
- ○ B. Meet them for a long discussion
- ○ C. Pay them for the work
- ○ D. Visit their office in person

58. Fill the gap

I haven't heard from my landlord all week, so I'm going to _____ with him tomorrow about the repairs.

59. Choose the best reply

Amira: *Are you still planning to travel with the group in March?*

- ○ A. Probably, but I touched base my passport last week and it's expired.
- ○ B. Probably, but I'll touch base the airport next month to buy a suitcase.
- ○ C. Probably, but I'll touch base with everyone next month once the dates are clear.

60. Your turn: speak

Tell me about a time when you needed to stay in contact with someone while working on something together.

_____

_____

_____

use it or lose it

Idiom | Level B1 | Casual

If you don't use a skill or something you have, you will lose it.

Tip: Use it as a short piece of advice or a warning, often after you mention a skill someone has learned; it works for languages, sports, instruments and any ability that fades without practice.

Olena: I did a month of Spanish lessons before our trip, but I haven't spoken a word since.

Diego: Really? You sounded great at the restaurant in Seville.

Olena: Thanks, but I'm already forgetting things. It's so frustrating.

Diego: That happens. Use it or lose it. Why don't we chat in Spanish for ten minutes at lunch?

Olena: Okay, but please be patient with me!

61. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does 'use it or lose it' mean?

- ○ A. If you don't practise a skill, you will slowly forget it.
- ○ B. You must choose one thing and give up the other.
- ○ C. You should spend your money before it disappears.
- ○ D. If you lose something, you should look for it quickly.

62. Fill the gap

I used to play the guitar every evening, but I stopped last year, and now my fingers feel slow.

_____ , I suppose.

63. Choose the best reply

Kofi: *I studied French for years at school, but now I can hardly remember any of it.*

- ○ A. Yes, use it or lose it. You should throw your old French books away.
- ○ B. Don't worry, use it or lose it means you can only keep one language.
- ○ C. Well, use it or lose it. Maybe try a short French video every day?

64. Your turn: speak

Tell me about a skill you learned in the past that you are now worse at. What happened?

_____

_____

_____

Answer key

breathing down your neck

1. B. Checking on his work all the time, which makes him feel pressure
2. breathing down my neck
3. A. I know, she's been breathing down your neck all week, hasn't she?
4. Example: Last year I was finishing a big project at university, and my supervisor was breathing down my neck about the deadline. She asked for updates almost every day, which made me quite stressed. In the end I finished on time, but I would have enjoyed the work more with a bit of space.

drop the ball

5. D. Diego failed to do something he had promised to do
6. dropped the ball
7. C. Sorry, I dropped the ball. I meant to do it and forgot.
8. Example: Last year I was supposed to renew my passport before a trip, but I completely dropped the ball and left it too late. I had to pay extra for a fast service, which was stressful and expensive. Now I put important deadlines in my calendar with two reminders.

get through

9. C. To finish a large amount of work, even though it takes effort
10. get through
11. A. Honestly, there was so much training that I could barely get through it.
12. Example: Last month I had three assignments due in the same week. I made a list and worked on one thing at a time, and I stopped checking my phone. In the end I got through everything, although I was very tired by Friday.

the ins and outs

13. C. All the small details of how something works
14. the ins and outs
15. C. Ask Diego. He knows the ins and outs of buying cars, so he can warn you about the common problems.
16. Example: I recently started using a new accounting program at work, and it was much more complicated than I thought. It took me a few weeks to understand the ins and outs of it, and I had to ask my colleagues for help a lot. Now I feel confident, and I can even show new people how to use it.

leeway

17. C. There is a little flexibility about the deadline.
18. leeway
19. A. Don't worry, they usually allow a bit of leeway on the first day.
20. Example: When I was moving house last year, my landlord gave me a bit of leeway with the date I had to leave. That meant I didn't have to rush, and I could pack calmly over an extra weekend. I was really grateful, because it took a lot of stress off me.

a leg up

21. D. An advantage that helps someone do better than others
22. a leg up
23. A. Don't worry. The summer course you took will give you a leg up.
24. Example: I think learning to type quickly really gave me a leg up when I started my first office job. I could finish reports faster than my colleagues, so my manager noticed me early on. It was a small skill, but it made a big difference.

make up (work or time)

25. A. Work extra hours to replace the hours he missed
26. make up
27. A. No problem. Do you want to make up the session with me tomorrow?
28. Example: Last winter I caught a cold and missed two days of classes. I borrowed notes from a friend, and then I stayed after school on Friday to make up the practical work I'd missed. It was tiring, but I didn't fall behind.

on my behalf

29. B. Instead of me, as my representative
30. on his behalf
31. B. Of course. Do you want me to introduce the project on your behalf?
32. Example: Last year I was travelling when a parcel arrived, so I asked my neighbour to collect it on my behalf. She had to show a message with my name and number, but it worked well. When I got home, the parcel was waiting for me on the kitchen table.

part and parcel

33. D. A normal and unavoidable part of something
34. part and parcel
35. A. Well, it's part and parcel of working in a hospital, I'm afraid.
36. Example: I've been learning the piano for two years, and practising scales is part and parcel of it. It can be really boring, but I know I can't get better without it. So I try to treat it as a warm-up and not as a chore.

pick someone's brain

37. A. Ask someone with experience for advice and ideas
38. pick her brain
39. A. Yes, I have. Want to meet up so you can pick my brain about it?
40. Example: Last year I wanted to switch careers, so I asked an old colleague who already worked in the field if I could pick her brain over lunch. She gave me honest advice about salaries and training courses that I couldn't have found online. It made my decision much easier.

side hustle

41. B. A small extra job you do besides your main job
42. side hustle
43. B. Maybe you could start a side hustle to bring in some extra money.
44. Example: I think it can be a good idea if you have the energy for it. A side hustle can bring in extra money and let you try something you enjoy. My cousin sells vintage clothes online after work, and she says she's learned a lot about running a small business.

spread yourself thin

45. C. Taking on so many commitments that you can't do any of them well
46. spreading yourself too thin
47. A. Wow, careful you don't spread yourself too thin.
48. Example: Yes, last year I was studying full time, working part time and helping at a community project. I was really spreading myself thin, and I started missing deadlines. In the end I stepped back from the project so I could focus on what mattered most.

team up

49. B. Work together with someone to get something done
50. team up

51. B. Don't worry, let's team up and do it together.
52. Example: Last year I had to move to a new apartment, and I had far too much to organise. I teamed up with my cousin, who is great at packing, while I handled the paperwork and the van. We finished in two days, which would have taken me a week alone.

toe the line

53. D. To follow the rules and behave as expected
54. toe the line
55. B. No, I'd rather toe the line until I've been here a bit longer.
56. Example: When I started my first job in a hospital office, I had to toe the line for the first few months because everything had to be done exactly the right way. It felt a bit restrictive at the time, but I learned a lot from it. Looking back, I think it helped me build good habits.

touch base

57. A. Contact them briefly to check on progress
58. touch base
59. C. Probably, but I'll touch base with everyone next month once the dates are clear.
60. Example: Last year I worked on a group project with two classmates who lived far away. We were all busy, so we agreed to touch base every Sunday evening with a short message or call. It kept everyone on track and nothing was forgotten.

use it or lose it

61. A. If you don't practise a skill, you will slowly forget it.
62. Use it or lose it
63. C. Well, use it or lose it. Maybe try a short French video every day?
64. Example: I used to swim quite well when I was a teenager because I went to the pool every week. After I started working, I stopped going, and last summer I got tired after just two lengths. It's true what they say: use it or lose it, so I've started going again on Sundays.